MASSACHUSETTS

The Bay State



The waters off the Massachusetts coast have never been gentle, but they have always been generous.

The Wampanoag people had mastered the art of harvesting the sea along what is now Cape Cod, Plymouth, and the islands beyond before settlers claimed the space. Clams—quahogs in particular, thick-shelled and briny—were a cornerstone of their diet, dug from the tidal flats at low water and cooked in earthen pits with heated stones and seaweed. They understood something fundamental about this coastline: that its greatest gifts came from patience, from reading the tides, and from knowing where to dig.

When English and French settlers arrived in the early 1600s, they brought with them a cooking tradition built around the pot—specifically the chaudière, the heavy iron cauldron that French fishermen hung over open fires on the docks of Brittany and Normandy. Along the fishing villages of coastal Massachusetts—Gloucester, Marblehead, Provincetown, and Boston's own waterfront—those pots were filled with whatever the day's catch offered. Salt pork rendered in the bottom for fat and flavor, onions softened in the drippings, local clams added by the bushel, and ship's biscuit or hardtack crumbled in to thicken the broth. It was practical food, built for men who worked in cold wind and needed something that stuck to the bones.

By the 1700s, Boston had grown into one of the busiest ports in the Atlantic world, and the waterfront was a loud, layered place—fishmongers, ship captains, merchants, and dockworkers moving alongside one another in the narrow streets below Faneuil Hall. Taverns along the wharves kept iron pots simmering through the day, and chowder was the reliable constant, cheap enough for a laborer and satisfying enough for a sea captain. It was in these kitchens that cream began replacing water in the broth, that potatoes—arriving in greater abundance through the mid-1800s—thickened the pot into something richer and more substantial. The Manhattan version, made with tomatoes, would come later and spark arguments that continue to this day along the New England coast. Here, the chowder stayed cream-white, unapologetically rich, and deeply local.

What survived all those centuries of refinement is one of the most deeply comforting dishes in the American kitchen. The briny sweetness of the clams against the silky cream, the soft potato, the smoky whisper of salt pork—it is the kind of bowl that makes a cold afternoon feel like something to be savored rather than endured. Make it on a grey day with good bread alongside, and you will understand immediately why generations of Massachusetts fishermen came home to it, why it earned its place on every table from Gloucester to the Cape, and why it has never once needed improving.

NEW ENGLAND CLAM CHOWDER

One spoonful of New England Clam Chowder is like a warm embrace from the sea—rich, creamy, and soul-deep satisfying.

Yield: 6–8 servings

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INGREDIENTS

- 4 dozen hard-shell clams (quahogs or cherrystones), scrubbed
- 4 cups water
- 4 slices salt pork (or thick-cut bacon), diced
- 1 medium onion, finely chopped
- 3 medium potatoes, peeled and diced (Yukon Gold or russet)
- 2 cups whole milk
- 1 cup heavy cream
- 2 Tbsp unsalted butter
- 2 Tbsp all-purpose flour (optional, for thicker chowder)
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- Fresh parsley, chopped, for garnish
- Oyster crackers, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Steam the Clams*: In a large pot, add clams and water. Cover and steam over medium heat until clams open, 8–10 minutes. Remove clams with a slotted spoon. Strain the broth through cheesecloth or a fine sieve to remove grit; reserve the clear broth. Once cooled, remove clam meat from shells and chop coarsely. Set aside.
2. *Render salt pork*: In a large Dutch oven, cook diced salt pork over medium heat until fat is rendered and pieces are lightly crisp. Remove and discard the solids, leaving the fat in the pot.
3. *Sauté the Aromatics*: Add onion to the pot with pork fat and cook until softened but not browned, 5 minutes.
4. *Cook the Potatoes*: Add the diced potatoes and enough reserved clam broth to just cover them (3 cups). Simmer until potatoes are tender, 15 minutes.
5. *Make it Creamy*: In a separate saucepan, warm the milk and cream, if not using flour to thicken. If you prefer a thicker chowder, sprinkle in the flour and cook 2 minutes before adding liquid. Gradually add the milk and cream to the large pot, stirring gently. Stir in butter.
6. *Add clams*: Stir in the chopped clams. Simmer for just 2–3 minutes. Do not boil, or clams will turn tough. Season with salt and pepper, to taste.
7. *Serve*: Ladle chowder into bowls, garnish with parsley, and serve hot with oyster crackers.

NOTES & TIPS

- Salt pork is the classic fat in Massachusetts chowder, though bacon is often used today.
- The broth should be creamy, not overly thick—chowder in New England is traditionally more about richness than heaviness.
- Some old recipes omit flour entirely, relying only on milk, cream, and potatoes for body.

